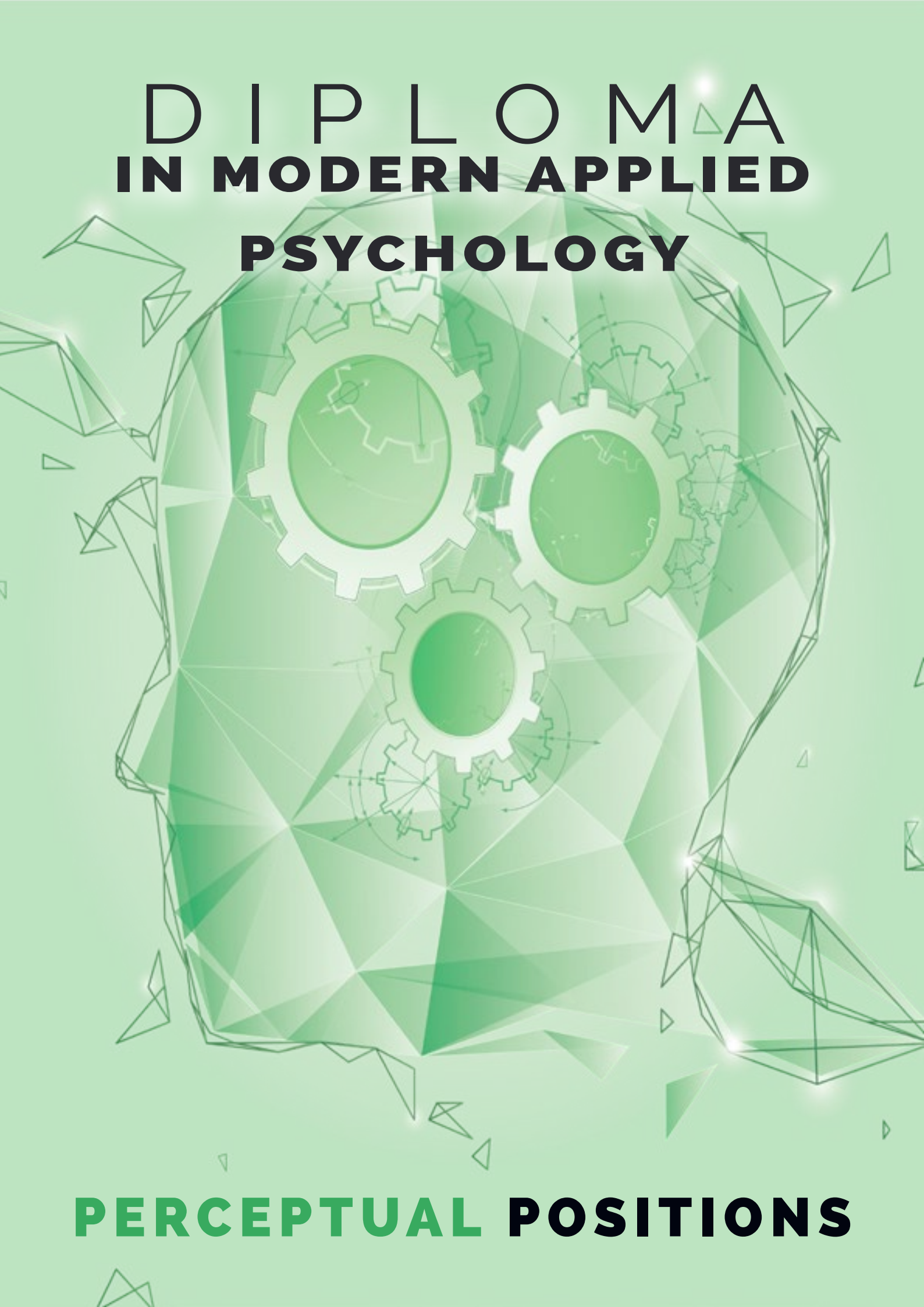


DIPLOMA IN MODERN APPLIED PSYCHOLOGY

The background is a vibrant green with a complex, low-poly geometric pattern. Overlaid on this is a faint, light green silhouette of a human head in profile, facing right. Inside the head, three interlocking gears of different sizes are visible, suggesting a connection between psychology and mechanics or technology. The overall aesthetic is modern and technical.

PERCEPTUAL POSITIONS

PERCEPTUAL POSITIONS

Perceptual Positions is an excellent technique and can be very useful in shifting a person's perceptual filters of experience. This unique process allows us to experience three separate sensory perspectives of an event, from that of our self to another and an objective observer.

Perceptual positions can be used to help an individual to step back from their limited perspective to get distance from their emotional interpretation of any given situation. You can use this technique as a life coach to better understand and empathise with your clients, for it will help you gain valuable insights into another individual's experience of the world.

We've all had an experience that annoyed or frustrated us long after the event occurred. Attached to this negative experience are feelings and, perhaps, some relevant images and sounds. The same process occurs for extremely positive experiences too; the internal feelings, images and sounds of holidays, special events, etc., can stay with a person long after the event. When you are fully in an experience like this, it's called 'first position'.

Have you ever found yourself walking, talking and using body posture and gestures similar to that of someone else? Almost as if you had become just like this person? Have you ever learned a new skill by acting as if you were the person who you know embodies the skills you are practising? In your mind's eye, you became this other person. Young children learn in the same way: by mimicking those around them. Actors also step into the shoes of another individual when playing a role. When you assume another person's perspective like this, it's called 'second position'.

Do you ever mentally step back from interaction and get the sense that you can see and hear yourself in those that you are interacting with? Almost as if you were watching events unfold on a cinema screen, and you were a character on the screen? When you step back and are able to observe yourself as a person outside of yourself, this is called 'third position'. This is a very powerful technique for improving the quality of our relationships: at home, socially or even at work. It allows us to understand another person's viewpoint — from their 'perspective' — which then allows you to use this insight to improve/adapt the way in which you communicate with them.

You can use the Perceptual Positions Technique to:

- Develop a better understanding of others.
- Think more creatively and be more flexible.
- Give yourself the opportunity to stand back and consider issues objectively.
- Better understand the impact of your verbal and non-verbal behaviour on others — and the impact of their behaviour on you.
- Review an interaction you've had with another person, or prepare for an important conversation.

Self-Reflection Exercise: Perceptual Positions

Take some time to complete the following exercise to better understand perceptual repositioning. Consider a situation involving someone else that has caused you frustration or a problem in your life.

Step 1. First Position:

Firstly, consider this situation from your own perspective. Imagine that you are witnessing the situation with your own eyes, looking at this other person. What do you see? What do you hear? Is this your own voice, your own self-talk? What is this other person saying to you? How are you behaving and reacting? How are you feeling?



PERCEPTUAL POSITIONS

This will give you information about the situation from your own perspective. Once you've gathered all the insights from Position 1, step out of that position.

Step 2. Second Position:

Now become the other person. Step into this other person's shoes and experience the situation completely from their perspective. What do they feel? Describe this situation as if you were the other person. Having gathered all the information from the other person's perspective, now step out of that position.

Step 3. Third Position:

This is where you reimagine the scene, and collect information from an objective, observer's stance. Imagine that you're a neutral, third party looking down at the situation. Gather information and describe what the situation's like according to the neutral third party observer. What does it look like when you consider things from this perspective?

Step 4.

Now consider what you've learned in second and third position and take these new learnings back to Position 1 and Position 2. How has your perspective changed in light of your new learnings?

This is a great (and very simple) technique to help either yourself or your clients, to become more mindfully aware of perspectives that are different from their own. Try it on someone (or, try it on yourself) and see!

Answer the following self-reflection questions to help you consider the ideas presented in this workbook in the context of your own life:

1. How has your appreciation of perceptual positions and the concept of looking at your experiences from other perspective has helped you become more relatable? Give some examples.

2. Can you identify any unhelpful thinking patterns which have become your default way of perceiving certain situations?



PERCEPTUAL POSITIONS

3. Can you think of any times when your unwillingness to consider other people's perspectives have cost you a connection?

4. Think of a relationship you've lost. What part has your communication played in the breakdown of a relationship?

5. If you put yourself in the other person's shoes, how do you think they would have perceived the relationship and how did they experience you? This isn't about guesswork - how do you know they experienced you?

6. Now imagine yourself being a fly on the wall watching your relationship - how would an objective outsider view your relationship? What would they think the people wanted and what would they think they were choosing - connection or disconnection?

